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PM's New Zealand Visit Will Unlock New Avenues of Cooperation: Govt.

PM's New Zealand visit will unlock new avenues of cooperation: govt.

Press Trust of India

AUCKLAND

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday arrived in New Zealand on the final leg of his three-nation visit.

He will hold talks with his counterpart Christopher Luxon and address the Indian diaspora in New Zealand.

Mr. Luxon received Mr. Modi at the airport. "This visit is historic, being the first Prime Ministerial visit to New Zealand in four decades. I look forward to holding talks with Prime Minister Luxon and discussing the complete range of the India-NZ friendship," Mr. Modi said in a post on X.

Boosting trade ties

During his two-day visit, he will hold talks with Mr.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with his New Zealand counterpart Christopher Luxon at the Auckland airport on Friday. ANI

Luxon on ways to enhance economic, trade and commercial engagements.

In a post on X, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said: "This historic visit is set to strengthen bilateral ties and unlock new avenues of cooperation across several areas especially trade, defence,

sports, culture, education, and people-to-people exchanges."

Mr. Modi arrived in New Zealand after concluding a three-day visit to Australia, where he held summit talks with Prime Minister Anthony Albanese. Both leaders reinforced the vital role of the bilateral part-

nership in ensuring a peaceful Indo-Pacific.

A major highlight of the summit talks between the two leaders was their focus on significantly ramping up defence ties, especially in the maritime domain. An agreement on civil nuclear energy to facilitate the commercial supply of uranium from Australia to India to fuel New Delhi's nuclear power projects was sealed after over two years of negotiations.

He also met Australia's Leader of the Opposition Angus Taylor on Friday and discussed bilateral ties.

Mr. Modi was in Indonesia before that, where 14 agreements were inked to boost cooperation in critical minerals, maritime security, and other key sectors.

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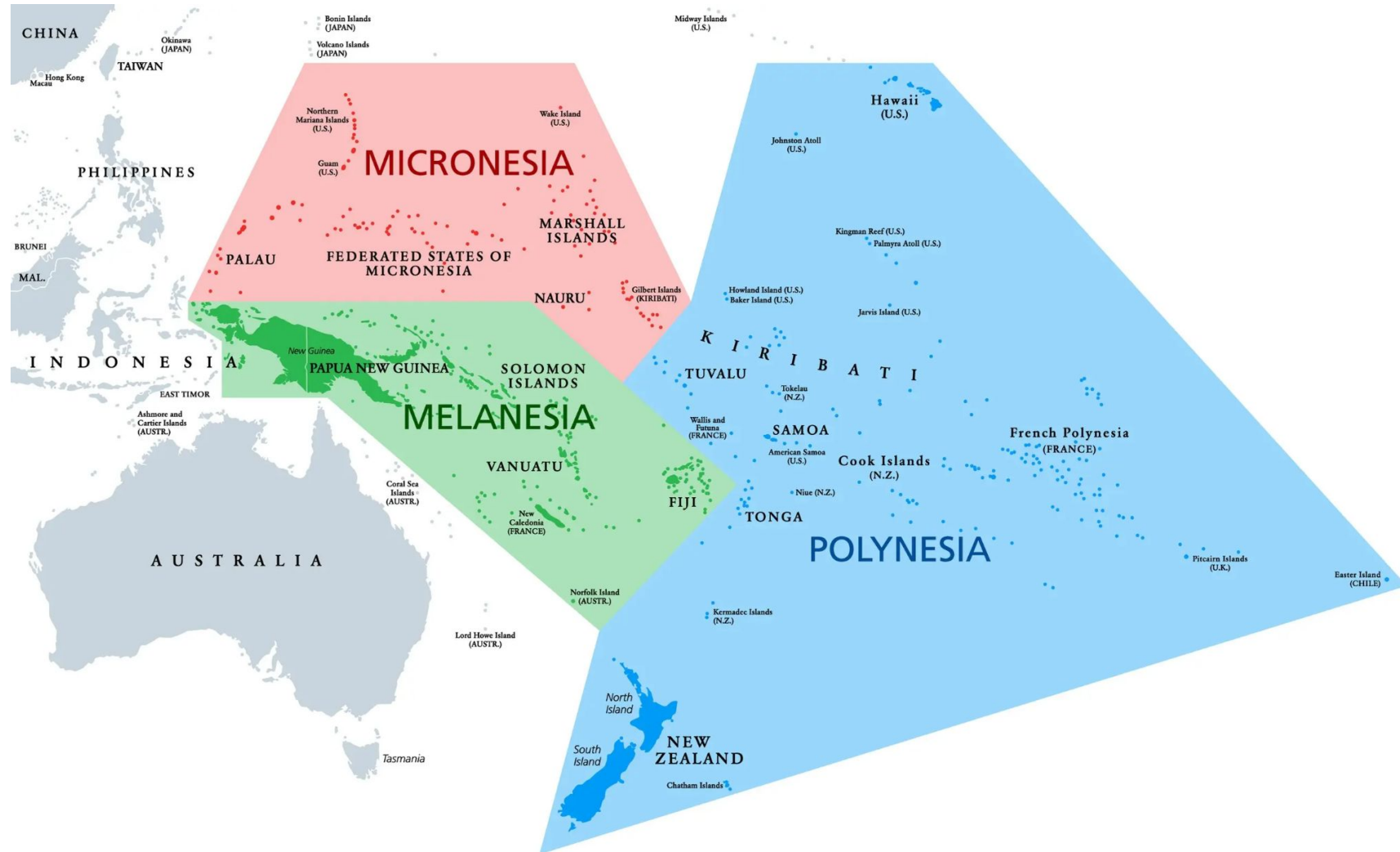
- **The Visit**

- PM Modi's New Zealand stop, the first Indian PM visit there in four decades, was the final leg of a three-nation tour covering Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand

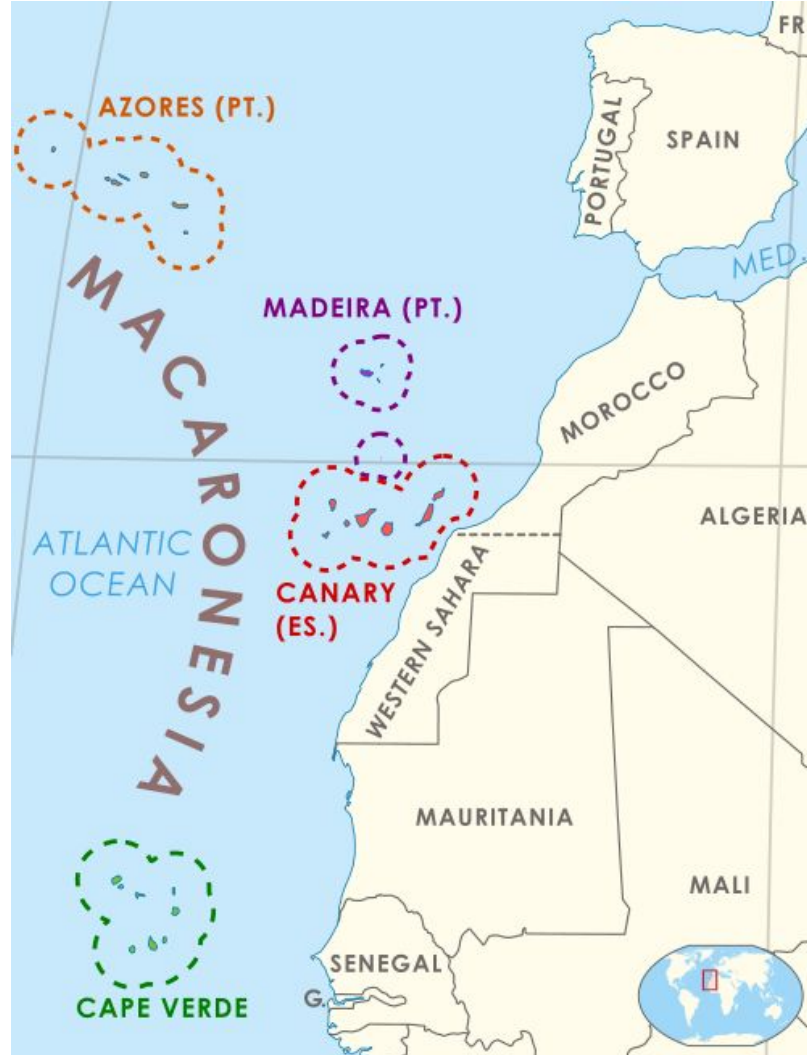
- **New Zealand Outcomes**

- Talks with PM Christopher Luxon focused on ramping up defence ties, especially maritime cooperation, alongside trade, sports, culture, education and people-to-people exchanges

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Each of the archipelagos is a distinct political entity: the Azores and Madeira are autonomous regions of Portugal, the Canary Islands is an autonomous community of Spain, while Cape Verde, a former Portuguese colony, is a sovereign state and member of the United Nations

The Azores are located in the triple junction between the Eurasian, African, and North American plates

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It is an island country and one of the many islands that make up Oceania.

It is located in the South Pacific Ocean to the southeast of Australia, south of New Caledonia, Fiji and Tonga Islands.

It is primarily divided into two main islands, the North Island and the South Island, **separated by the Cook Strait.**

Capital City: Wellington

It is part of the Pacific Ring of Fire, the circum-Pacific seismic belt marked by frequent earthquakes and considerable volcanic activity.

Representing the southwesternmost geographic anchor of Polynesia, it stands as a highly developed **constitutional monarchy with a parliamentary democracy**

The social and cultural gap between New Zealand's two main groups—**the indigenous Māori of Polynesian heritage** and the colonizers and later immigrants from the British Isles and their descendants—has decreased since the 1970s, though educational and economic differences between the two groups remain.

Conservation Projects for River Dolphins, 3 Other Species Approved

Conservation projects for river dolphins, 3 other species approved

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

The governing body of the National Compensatory Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority (CAMPA) on Friday gave nod to four new conservation projects for river dolphins, snow leopards, wild water buffalo, and Indian rhinoceros.

The projects approved are studies on the conservation and recovery action plan for river dolphins,



The governing body of National CAMPA approved a new scheme with an initial corpus of ₹3,000 crore over five years.

Project Snow Leopard Phase-II (including second cycle of population estimation), the conservation ac-

tion plan for the Indian Rhinoceros, and a pan-India conservation approach for the wild water buffalo.

Conservation Projects for River Dolphins, 3 Other Species Approved

- **The Approval**

- The governing body of the National Compensatory Afforestation Fund Management and Planning Authority (CAMPA) approved four new conservation projects for river dolphins, snow leopards, wild water buffalo and Indian rhinoceros

- **River Dolphin Project**

- A study on the conservation and recovery action plan for river dolphins, supported by a new scheme with an initial corpus of Rs 3,000 crore over five years

- **Project Snow Leopard Phase-II**

- Includes a second cycle of population estimation, building on India's existing Project Snow Leopard

- **Rhino and Buffalo Conservation**

- Includes a conservation action plan for the Indian Rhinoceros and a pan-India conservation approach for the wild water buffalo

- **Significance**

- Reflects a broadening of India's species-specific conservation architecture beyond flagship species like the tiger and lion, funded through the compensatory afforestation mechanism

Conservation Projects for River Dolphins, 3 Other Species Approved

- **Gangetic River Dolphin** is India's **national aquatic animal**.
- **Distribution**: India, Bangladesh and Nepal.
- **4 freshwater dolphin species in the world**: The Gangetic River dolphin, Irrawaddy dolphin in Myanmar (both marine and freshwater), Indus River dolphin in Pakistan and Amazon River dolphin in South America.
- **Bihar is home to around half of the estimated 3,000 Gangetic dolphins in India.**
- **It is blind and finds its way and prey in river waters through echolocation.**
- **Exclusively a freshwater species,** they are functionally blind and rely on ultrasonic echolocation to locate prey.
- It is locally called '**Susu**' due to the sound it makes while exhaling.
- **Project Dolphin**: Implements special conservation measures for Gangetic River Dolphins, recognized as umbrella species.
- **Vikramshila Ganges Dolphin Sanctuary** has been established in Bihar. It is India's only dedicated dolphin sanctuary.

Conservation Projects for River Dolphins, 3 Other Species Approved

Q. Which one of the following is the national aquatic animal of India? (2015)

- (a) Saltwater crocodile
- (b) Olive ridley turtle
- (c) Gangetic dolphin
- (d) Gharial

A Future of Financial Health for Every Indian

A future of financial health for every Indian

Nar has been working for 45 years and is one of the longest-serving caddies at his golf club. Although he had a bank account for years, like many informal workers, he was focused on earning a living and supporting his family, leaving little opportunity to plan for the future.

That changed three years ago when he learned about the National Pension System and began saving for retirement for the first time. Today, his fund is growing, giving him confidence that after a lifetime of hard work, he can retire with financial security and dignity.

The meaning of financial health

In June 2026, I visited India in my capacity as the United Nations Secretary-General's Special Advocate for Financial Health. I have been advocating for and learning about efforts to improve financial health, which means ensuring that people have the right financial policies, products, and services to manage day-to-day expenses, stay resilient when unexpected shocks occur, invest in and save for long- and short-term goals, and have confidence in the future.

In practice, this is like Nar's experience – going beyond having a bank account to having investments that will help him in the future. It could also mean a person having affordable home insurance to help if a flash flood causes damage to their house. Or, it could mean receiving responsible credit to help with bills during a tough month.

India has recently undergone a remarkable transformation. According to the World Bank's Global Findex, account ownership among adults has risen from around 56% to 89% in just 10 years. This progress in access is impressive, and it creates an opportunity to do more to support people's financial health.

A financial health approach will be beneficial not just for families but also for the country. Household and individual-level financial health are crucial for country-level resilient growth and prosperity.

The Viksit Bharat 2047 goal to move from



Queen Máxima

of the Netherlands,
is the United Nations
Secretary-General's
Special Advocate for
Financial Health

India's next leap
should be to
ensure financial
health for all

"welfare to wealth creation" would also be well supported by efforts to improve financial health, under the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

During my visit, I saw how so many in India – from the highest levels of government to pioneering fintech companies – are doing financial health work.

In New Delhi, I spoke with informal sector workers, who are now able to save, plan, and retire without relying on their children, thanks to opening retirement accounts with support from Universal Pensions. In Mumbai, I spoke with nurses at a hospital who have found more financial stability and decreased stress through workplace financial health products offered by SalarySe, such as responsible credit, individualised financial health scores, and insurance.

I met with regulators and bank leaders who are using innovation and Artificial Intelligence (AI) to help households make better financial decisions, grow their savings and investments, build resilience through access to insurance, and tackle challenges such as fraud and scams. Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra and I discussed how India can expand on these opportunities to support financial health in the country.

Steps to take

In my conversations with Indian people from different walks of life, I heard directly how financial products and services could further build their trust in institutions and give them the support that they need to improve their financial lives. I want to thank the people in Mumbai and New Delhi who shared their stories with me.

Four actions will help move financial health forward:

First, further develop Jan Dhan 2.0 with financial health at the centre. As the Pradhan Mantri Jan-Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) enters its second decade, there is an opportunity to transform accounts from simple payment and cash-withdrawal channels into a household

financial resilience platform. This means fully integrating the PMJDY with Direct Benefit Transfers (DBTs), PM-KISAN, MGNREGA wage payments (now VB-G RAM-G), e-Shram, the Atal Pension Yojana (APY), Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana (PMJJBY), Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana (PMSBY), and other social protection schemes for informal and gig workers.

Linking these programmes through a single account could help households build their financial health. Women, who hold the majority of PMJDY accounts, could particularly benefit, as would informal workers, migrants, and gig economy workers.

Second, build on India's robust digital public infrastructure to support better financial health. Innovations such as MahaVISTAAR, account aggregators, the Unified Lending Interface (ULI), DigiLocker, and emerging AI applications create opportunities to strengthen household financial capability, choice and agency at scale.

Third, use India's rich ecosystem of household surveys, administrative datasets, and digital infrastructure to gather data on financial health. This data could be used to strengthen policymaking, protect consumers, and ensure that the financial sector is accountable.

Public-private collaboration

Finally, build on the momentum to further mobilise financial institutions, employers, and market players. Government and regulators play a critical role in advancing households' financial health. The impact is amplified when it is a joint effort with the private sector. Countries including the Netherlands and Indonesia are already pursuing such public-private collaboration.

The vision of financial health is giving every person a better today, tomorrow, and future. Just as Nar should have the opportunity to save for a well-deserved restful retirement, all Indian families should have the financial policies, tools, and services that they need to thrive throughout their lives. After my visit in June, I am looking forward to working with the Government of India to make this vision a reality.

A Future of Financial Health for Every Indian

- **Defining Financial Health**

- Beyond having a bank account, financial health means having the right policies, products and services to manage expenses, stay resilient to shocks, save for goals, and have confidence in the future

- **India's Progress**

- **Per the World Bank's Global Findex, account ownership among Indian adults rose from around 56% to 89% in just ten years, creating a strong foundation to build financial health further**

- **Ground Observations**

- Informal sector workers are now saving via Universal Pensions; workplace financial health products (responsible credit, insurance, individualised financial scores) are reaching employees through fintech partnerships

- **Four Recommended Actions**

- **Develop Jan Dhan 2.0 as a household financial resilience platform integrating DBTs and welfare schemes; build on digital public infrastructure (ULI, DigiLocker, AI); use household survey data for policy making; deepen public-private collaboration**

Landslides: The Need for Early Warning Systems

Landslides: The need for early warning systems

Amitabh Sinha
New Delhi, July 10

THE LANDSLIDES in recent days in the Western Ghats and other parts of India have reignited discussions on the need for an early warning system for such events.

Creating warning systems

Landslides can indeed be predicted, at least in highly prone areas such as Wayanad — where a 2024 landslide killed more than 300 people. Early warning system can be installed for timely evacuations from danger zones. Such systems already work effectively in many countries.

In India, too, such systems have worked in the past. Barely two weeks before the 2024 landslides in Wayanad, a series of landslides in the hills of Munnar (further south in Kerala) saw no loss of life. This was partly because the Idukki district administration evacuated people on the advice of a team of researchers from Amrita University, who were testing an early warning system. Led by Maneesha Vinodini Ramesh, it is one of many groups developing such systems in collaboration with government agencies.

Range of models

Recently, Professor Dericks Praise Shukla and his team at IIT Mandi have unveiled their own landslide early warning system, which is in the process of getting validated with ongoing events in the Himalayan region.

RISK ZONES

- IIT Mandi professor Dericks Praise Shukla said the north-western Himalayan region and parts of Manipur and Mizoram are vulnerable to landslides.
- Sikkim is relatively less vulnerable due to a less dense road network, which implies greater stability, he said.

beyond certain well-defined thresholds, then a warning is issued, and the administration can take action," he said.

"Scientifically, this is a very robust method, and gives plenty of lead time to plan and execute evacuations. This is how early warning systems are operating in other countries as well. The one limitation is that you get the information only about the slope where the instruments are installed, nothing about the neighbouring slope. Landslides are highly localised events," he said.

Shukla has been using a probabilistic forecasting method to track possibilities of landslides in the Himalayan region. His team has mapped vulnerable spots in the region using a satellite-based database of past events.

Since rainfall is one of the most common triggers, the team uses highly localised rainfall forecasts to model the probability of a landslide. Other relevant factors, like soil conditions, rock stability, extent of slope and population density, have to be fed into the model. "Very localised rainfall forecast is available only on that particular date or a day earlier. So, our method does not give a very long lead time. Once higher-resolution rainfall forecasts, which India Meteorological Department is working on, become available, landslide forecasts can be made much earlier," Shukla said.

"A comprehensive and effective early warning system for landslides can be prepared in about two years if resources and effort are properly dedicated to it. Within the areas prone to landslides, we must identify high-risk areas where landslides are frequent... Once this gets done, we can install sensors at selected sites," he said.

Landslides: The Need for Early Warning Systems

- **The Trigger**

- Recent landslides in the Western Ghats and elsewhere have reignited discussions on early warning systems, following the 2024 Wayanad landslide that killed over 300 people

- **Proof of Concept : Munnar**

- Days before the Wayanad disaster, landslides in Munnar (Kerala) saw no loss of life, partly because Idukki authorities evacuated people based on warnings from an Amrita University research team

- **IIT Mandi's System**

- Professor Dericks Praise Shukla's team has developed a landslide early warning system for the Himalayan region, using a network of sensors (tilt meters, pressure gauges, accelerometers) at high-risk sites

- **How It Works**

- Sensors report values beyond well-defined thresholds, triggering warnings; the method is highly localised, providing information only about the specific instrumented slope, not neighbouring areas

- **Rainfall-Based Forecasting Limits**

- Since rainfall is a key trigger, the model incorporates localised rainfall forecasts, soil conditions and slope data; a comprehensive system could be built in about two years with adequate resources

Crackdown on Cybercrime: Rs 25,000 cr Saved, Rs 323 cr Refunded, e-Zero FIR Rolled Out

Crackdown on cybercrime: Rs 25,000 cr saved, Rs 323 cr refunded, e-Zero FIR rolled out

2.75 lakh URLs,
233 apps, 3,691
websites blocked
in 5 years, MHA
officials brief PM

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 10

CYBERFRAUD PREVENTION worth more than Rs 25,000 crore, a money restoration module to give refunds to victims and the rollout of an e-Zero FIR initiative were among the key points presented for the first time before Prime Minister Narendra Modi during his meeting with the secretaries of Central ministries last week, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

At the meeting, which lasted around four hours, PM Modi was informed that the union Ministry of Home Affairs had launched a new e-Zero FIR system last year. Under this system, cyber financial crime complaints lodged through the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal or the cyber helpline number 1930 are automatically converted into e-Zero FIRs if the reported loss exceeds Rs 10 lakh.

India recorded 98 lakh cybercrime complaints between



GETTY IMAGES

August 2019 and May 2026, while only 2.3 lakh FIRs were registered during the same period. This translates into an FIR conversion rate of 2.36%.

Currently, the e-Zero FIR initiative has been launched in Delhi, Haryana, Odisha, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Goa, Chandigarh, West Bengal, Rajasthan and Assam. "PM Modi was informed that the process of implementing the e-Zero FIR initiative in at least 19 more states and union Territories is underway," a source said.

This was PM Modi's second major institutional interaction with top bureaucrats in less than two months. On May 21, he chaired a joint meeting of the union Council of Ministers and Central Secretaries to develop regulatory roadmaps to realise the vision of 'Viksit Bharat'.

At the meeting, the Home

Ministry officials also briefed PM Modi that the Centre had blocked around 2.75 lakh URLs, 233 apps and 3,691 websites in the last five years for allegedly containing "material prejudicial to the sovereignty and integrity of India" under the Information Technology Act.

Between 2021 and May 2026, people reported cybercrime losses of Rs 64,447 crore. Of this, Rs 10,718 crore was frozen as lien. Only Rs 323 crore has been refunded to victims, a source said.

"Immediate interventions by the Centre have helped prevent fraud worth Rs 25,095 crore. Also, Rs 2.27 crore transactions were declined, around 12.1 lakh mule accounts were debit-frozen, and 31.6 lakh suspect identifiers were flagged with the help of the suspect registry," the source said.

The Home Ministry officials also informed the PM that 1,596 banks and financial institutions have been onboarded on the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal's Citizen Financial Cyber Frauds Reporting and Management System.

They briefed PM Modi on the ministry's plans, including setting up state and regional cybercrime coordination centres, and training police personnel to make them cyber commandos, a source said.

Crackdown on Cybercrime: Rs 25,000 cr Saved, Rs 323 cr Refunded, e-Zero FIR Rolled Out

How e-Zero FIR Works

- **Cyber financial crime complaints via the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal or helpline 1930 are automatically converted into e-Zero FIRs if the reported loss exceeds Rs 10 lakh; live in 9 states/UTs, expanding to 19 more**
- **Zero FIR is an FIR that can be registered by any police station, irrespective of jurisdiction, when it receives a complaint regarding a cognisable offence.**
- **Zero FIR was introduced after the recommendation of the Justice Verma Committee, which was set up after the 2012 Nirbhaya gangrape case.**

Thank You